

Why are economics so important to understanding the sources of ethnic (or racial) conflict?

How does Bayor's comparison between the economic situation of various ethnic groups during the interwar period lay the groundwork for understanding why ethnic conflict emerged in New York City during the Depression, and why it broke out between particular groups?

comparison

How it helps understand why ethnic conflict emerged

How it helps understand why ethnic conflict broke out between specific groups

Chapter Two

Economic Collapse

The first jolt to harmonious ethnic relations in New York City came from the economic system. When prosperity existed and jobs were plentiful, it was easier to accept the rivalry of other groups. As a result of the Depression and other factors, competition became sharp for increasingly scarce resources. The result, although different for each group depending on their particular place in the occupational structure, was an increase in the ethnic tensions and hostilities which had remained relatively submerged during the 1920s. To understand fully the economic aspect of conflict, one must consider not only the degree of unemployment during the Depression but also the occupational patterns of the period, which would have indicated problems for certain groups even if there had been no economic collapse.

PRE-DEPRESSION TRENDS

In the period from 1910 to 1930 the trend both in the United States and in New York State was away from unskilled labor. A study published by the State University of New York in 1937 notes a 67.3 percent increase in the white-collar and proprietary group during this period, while manual workers had increased by only 21.7 percent. (The rate of increase for all gainfully occupied workers in New York State was 38 percent.) Moreover, the percentage of manual workers among all gainful workers had declined from 64.4 percent in 1910 to 56.8 percent in 1930. Skilled workers showed the smallest decline within this category. The study also found that, within the grouping of manual workers, unskilled workers had increased by 5.4 percent, semi-skilled by 23.4 percent, and skilled by 34.3 percent. This shows that white-collar and more highly skilled

manual occupations were the expanding fields. Within the white-collar and proprietary group, clerks and kindred workers showed the largest increase (106.3 percent). Professional persons indicated an increase of 85.8 percent and non-farm proprietors, managers, and officials showed the smallest increase in this category, with 39.7 percent.¹

The same trend away from unskilled labor can be noted by looking at the occupational structure by census occupational divisions combined with the above data on socioeconomic groups. The declining occupational categories in New York State for the period 1910–1930 were agriculture, mining, the manufacturing and mechanical industries, and domestic and personal service.² Agriculture and mining can be disregarded, since they do not apply to New York City; but the figures for the remaining two categories are revealing. In the declining manufacturing and mechanical industries the trend was for skilled labor to supplant the less skilled. Skilled manual occupations increased more rapidly (32.6 percent) than the semi-skilled (5.6 percent) or unskilled (16.5 percent). Most of the semi-skilled workers were factory operatives; most of the unskilled were factory laborers. This occupational division also showed an increase in its white-collar and proprietary category, although less than in other fields owing to a significant decrease in builders and building contractors between 1910 and 1920. However, even this declining industry indicated a trend toward white-collar and skilled manual labor. The domestic and personal service division noted a decline because of the shift of women away from this occupation to clerical and professional positions. The only part of this category which showed an increase was the proprietary group (e.g., lunchroom and restaurant keepers).

The expanding census occupational divisions also exhibit a trend toward white-collar work. The clerical field increased enormously (130.2 percent) during this period, especially owing to the movement of women into occupations such as stenographers, typists, and clerks.³ This took place mainly during the World War I years. There was also a sharp rise in the professional service occupations (mostly professional persons), which increased at the rate of 95.6 percent during these twenty years. This figure included increases among such occupations as teachers, lawyers, and social workers. The public service occupations also were growing rapidly, at the rate of 77.2 percent, for the 1910–1930 period, with increases in white-collar as well as manual occupations. Taking the state and municipal civil service separately, the rate of increase (104 percent) was greater than that for most of the other occupational divisions. This was one of the most rapidly expanding categories. Trade also showed growth during this period (56.1 percent). Clerks and proprietors were increasing the fastest in this field (73.2 percent and 49.7 percent respectively), while manual workers increased at the slowest rate (11.5 percent). In the transportation and communication category the increase was 57.7 percent, with the same pattern emerging.

This was the situation in New York State up to the time of the Depression—a continuing increase in the white-collar and proprietary fields and,

among manual workers, in the higher-skilled positions. There was also a particularly substantial growth in clerical, professional service, and civil service occupational divisions. The expanding socioeconomic and occupational categories, which provided greater job opportunities up to 1930, for the most part also did so during the Depression.

THE DEPRESSION TRENDS

Of the industrial divisions for New York City (see table 1), the manufacturing and mechanical exhibited the highest percentage of unemployment at the beginning of the Depression.⁴ The majority of people in this industry were manual rather than white-collar workers, although it cannot be determined whether it was the skilled, semi-skilled, or unskilled workers who formed the bulk of the unemployed. Specifically, within this category, the building industry showed 18.6 percent of its gainful workers out of a job. Public service, at 1.1 percent, had the smallest percentage of its workers unemployed and was the most stable industrial grouping, the least affected by the Depression at this time. This category included all civil service occupations. Professional service and trade also proved to be relatively stable.

In terms of persons laid off from their jobs, the manufacturing category was again the highest (2.1 percent), public service the lowest (.1 percent). Relief figures for 1934 substantiate this picture of selective unemployment. Using data from the 1930 census and an urban relief survey of 1934, the Works Progress

Table 1. Unemployment by Industry in New York City, 1930

Industry	% of gainful workers unemployed and seeking work
Manufacturing and mechanical	10.1
Transportation and communication	5.8
Domestic and personal service	5.3
Trade	4.1
Professional service	4.1
Public service	1.1

SOURCE: United States, Department of Commerce, Bureau of the Census, *Fifteenth Census of the United States, 1930: Unemployment*, 1:709-10.

NOTE: Nonurban industries such as mining and agriculture were excluded from this table, although they were included in the census data.

Administration (W.P.A.) was able to produce statistics which indicated how various industries were affected by the Depression⁵ (see table 2).

As table 2 shows, the manufacturing and mechanical industries indicated a much higher proportion of workers on relief than would be expected from their percentage of all gainful workers. This was the most severely affected industrial category. Public service, professional service, and trade were under-represented in the relief column. The others were approximately the same as their share of all gainful workers. More specifically, within these general categories, only the building and construction industry (part of the manufacturing and mechanical division) showed a particularly disproportionate percentage of workers on relief (20.2 percent of all workers on relief but only 7.5 percent of all gainful workers).⁶ This is not to say that some occupations were unaffected by the Depression. By the end of the 1930s all had been affected, although in varying degrees.⁷

According to the 1940 census which surveyed the labor force in New York City (see table 3), the industry with the largest percentage of its experienced workers seeking employment was construction (considered separately in this survey), with 31.3 percent.⁸ Professional and public service (government) were still relatively secure. Within the professional category, the educational services reported a figure of 6.1 percent of their workers seeking employment. Within the government category, state and local government reported a figure of 3.5 percent.

It is also necessary to look at occupational groupings to determine how severely each industry and worker was affected. The 1934 relief survey indicated that certain occupations in New York City were more adversely affected than others by the Depression.⁹ All occupations (white-collar and manual) associated

Table 2. Relief by Industry in New York City, 1934

Industry	% of all gainful workers, 1930	% of all workers on relief, 1934
Manufacturing and mechanical	35.3	49.8
Transportation and communication	10.9	10.2
Trade	24.2	17.4
Domestic and personal service	14.1	15.5
Professional service	8.8	4.8
Public service	2.3	.7

SOURCE: United States, Works Progress Administration, Division of Social Research, *Urban Workers on Relief: The Occupational Characteristics of Workers on Relief in 79 Cities, May, 1934* (by Katherine D. Wood), part 2 (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1937), p. 99.

NOTE: Nonurban industries were excluded from this table although they were included in the relief survey.

Table 3. Unemployment by Industry in New York City, 1940

Industry ^a	% of experienced workers seeking work
Manufacturing	12.6
Construction	31.3
Transportation and communication	9.4
Wholesale and retail trade	11.7
Finance, insurance, and real estate	7.9
Business and repair services	13.5
Personal services	12.0
Amusement, recreation, and related services	25.8
Professional and related services	6.1
Government	3.5

SOURCE: United States, Department of Commerce, Bureau of the Census, *Sixteenth Census of the United States, 1940: Population: The Labor Force*, 3:460–61.

NOTE: Persons on public emergency work such as W.P.A. were not included in the census data.

^aNonurban industries were excluded from this table, although they were included in the census data.

with the construction industry showed a disproportionately high relief percentage in that the occupation indicated a higher proportion of all workers on relief than it did of all gainful workers.¹⁰ All semiskilled factory operatives in such industries as clothing were also over-represented. The same was true of most unskilled laborers and workers such as longshoremen and chauffeurs and truck drivers. Occupations which were under-represented in relief included most skilled workers not associated with construction, including bakers and tailors, and most white-collar and proprietary positions such as clerks, salesmen, proprietors and retail dealers in trade, and teachers. Public service workers also were under-represented. The vulnerability of certain occupations, of the manual more than the white-collar and proprietary, and of the unskilled more than the skilled is further illustrated by the 1940 occupational statistics.

Table 4 shows that unskilled laborers fared the worst, while those in the protective service and proprietary category were least subject to unemployment during the Depression. Most occupations in professional work also indicated low percentages, although musicians and entertainers showed a high rate of unemployment within this category and drove this figure up. As the trend has already indicated, all occupations (white-collar and manual) associated with construction had higher percentages of its workers unemployed. For example, among proprietors, managers, and officials, those in manufacturing (3.3 percent) and in wholesale (4.1 percent) and retail trade (4.2 percent) were in a better position than those in construction (8.6 percent). In the craftsmen category, machinists and toolmakers (9.5 percent) and tailors and furriers (14.8 percent) were in a

Table 4. Unemployment by Occupation in New York City, 1940

Occupation ^a	% of experienced workers seeking work
Professional and semiprofessional workers	9.5
Proprietors, managers, and officials (excluding farm)	4.6
Clerical, sales, and kindred workers	11.5
Craftsmen, foremen, and kindred workers	16.9
Operatives and kindred workers	14.5
Domestic service workers	11.9
Protective service workers	8.9
Service workers (other than domestic and protective)	11.8
Laborers	27.1

SOURCE: United States, Department of Commerce, Bureau of the Census, *Sixteenth Census of the United States, 1940: Population: The Labor Force*, 3:363-65.

NOTE: Persons on public emergency work were not included in the census tabulation.

^aNonurban occupations were excluded from this table although they were included in the census data.

relatively more secure occupation than those with construction skills, such as carpenters (25.3 percent) and plasterers and cement finishers (30.8 percent). This was also true among unskilled laborers.

Except for a few occupations such as musicians (27.2 percent) and some fields in clerical and sales such as shipping clerks (16.9 percent), the white-collar and proprietary categories and those who could be identified in civil service indicated the lowest percentages seeking work. This would include teachers (5.4 percent), proprietors, managers, and officials in retail trade (4.2 percent), and firemen and policemen (1.6 percent), classified in protective services. By the 1940 census, skilled workers did not fare better than the semiskilled except in the service fields, but both were in a better position than the unskilled. The Depression therefore mainly struck hardest at the industrial, occupational, and socioeconomic categories which had offered fewest opportunities before. However many workers in all occupations were adversely affected. For example, the proportion of the total population of the City who were gainfully employed declined from 46 percent in 1930 to 38 percent in 1940. In 1935 one out of every three workers who had been gainfully occupied in 1930 was unemployed. Relief figures also indicated the extent of the economic collapse. The peak period for relief in New York City was October 1935. After this date a downward trend began, continuing until the end of 1937, when relief figures again began to rise and continued to do so into 1938 during the so-called Roosevelt Recession. Relief numbers, however, never again reached the 1935 peak.¹¹ Not until the Second World War period could the Depression be considered over. By 1943

there was a substantial increase in the number of factory wage earners, and essentially in the employment of practically all the employable labor.¹²

With this background, we can now look at where the various ethnic groups fit into the occupational structure and determine whether this had any effect on the development of conflict.

ITALIAN AND JEWISH OCCUPATIONS: THE EARLY YEARS

The Italians, predominantly of peasant background, found themselves mainly in the unskilled laboring class during their early years in America. According to reports of the Immigration Commission in 1911, of 1,471,659 Italian immigrants admitted to the United States in the 1899–1910 period and reporting an occupation, 34.5 percent were considered in the category of farm laborer and 42.5 percent as general laborers. Only 14.6 percent were classified as having a skilled occupation. A 1903 immigration study noted that only .2 percent of Italian immigrants had been engaged in professional occupations in Italy; 12.7 percent had been employed in trades or industry and 64.9 percent had worked in agricultural positions. The remaining 22.2 percent were women and children.¹³

According to an analysis of the Immigration Commission's data from the 1900 census, among the foreign-born Italian males in the United States who were skilled, the concentration was strongest in the occupations of tailor and mason (brick and stone). This would indicate movement into the clothing and building fields. For all immigrant Italian males (skilled and unskilled) the occupation of greatest over-representation was that of peddler. Laborers also showed a significant overconcentration of Italians.¹⁴

The Immigration Commission reported in 1911 that among the ethnic groups in the City, the Italians had the highest proportion of common laborers, with the Irish in second place. It has also been noted, however, that by 1911 Italians made up more than a majority of the City's barbers and "more than one-third of the [City's] boot and shoemakers and repairers," both skilled trades. Growing numbers of this ethnic group also entered the longshoremen trade. In addition many Italians were becoming merchants who operated fruit stands, bakerys, or wine shops in the early years of the twentieth century. There was also a slight entry into clerical positions by the Italian second generation as of 1905.¹⁵

The Jews, arriving at essentially the same time, were more ably fitted for entrance into an occupational structure that was becoming more oriented to the higher-skilled and white-collar positions. The Immigration Commission reports of 1911 noted that of 590,267 Jewish immigrants admitted between 1899 and 1910 and reporting an occupation, 67.1 percent were considered skilled, while only 13.7 percent were either farm or nonfarm laborers. The Jews were skilled or semiskilled in industrial work and entered the United States in such occupations

So
Jews
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as furriers, tailors, dressmakers and seamstresses, watchmakers, and milliners. Almost half of the skilled were in the garment trades. An analysis of the Immigration Commission's data from the 1900 census revealed that foreign-born Russians (Jews) were over-represented as tailors, peddlers, tobacco and cigar factory operatives and merchants (except wholesale). Also the proportion of this group "in the professions was high for the non-English speaking immigrants." A view of the 1905 New York Eastern European Jewish occupational structure further indicates their movement into clerical work (by both first and second generation) and their involvement in various skilled trades such as housepainting and carpentry.¹⁶

One historian who traced Italian and Jewish individual occupational mobility from 1880 to 1915 noted that although both groups were upwardly mobile, the Jews were moving faster into white-collar positions and had a larger percentage of their workers in this category than the Italians. The background of the Jewish and Italian immigrants is important for understanding their occupational position within the City during the 1930s.¹⁷ The Jews, more so than the Italians, were the group who emerged as the major competitors for some of the more stable upper-level jobs held by the older ethnics. This is explained both by differences in the occupational positions of the Jews and Italians upon their arrival in America and by differences in their attitudes toward education.

JEWISH AND ITALIAN EDUCATIONAL VIEWS

Jews The Jews have traditionally considered education and scholastic achievement to be of great value. Because learning has given the Jewish individual an enhanced status within the community, the school was always an important institution to this ethnic group. Even during the early settlement period, school officials considered Jewish children to be excellent scholars.¹⁸ *upside of economic attainment*

Italians In the southern Italian culture, however, a different sentiment existed toward schools and formal education. The agricultural economy of this region made the child's labor important to the sustenance of the family. Therefore, there was no time or need for schooling. Education represented an alien undertaking intended only for priests and the upper class. While education did not benefit the peasant in any way, it could threaten him by jeopardizing family unity. For example, since priests were removed from their families for schooling, the desire to keep the family intact militated against extensive education in this direction. Beyond this, the school system in southern Italy was inadequate and controlled by people who had little interest in uplifting the peasantry. Therefore, many South Italians who entered America were illiterate.¹⁹

The fears did not abate when Southern Italians arrived in America. They held the same hostilities to schooling, for basically the same reasons. Schools prevented children from securing jobs and therefore from contributing to the

family income. The number of unskilled jobs available during the early years of Italian arrival made both children and parents consider schooling to be unnecessary. Moreover, many Italian immigrants still felt concern that school would alienate the child from the family and inculcate him with ideas "contrary to all Italian codes of proper family life." (This, of course, was experienced to some degree by all immigrant families who were concerned about the schools' Americanizing influence and its contempt for the immigrant culture.) It was also feared that education might have the effect of diminishing a boy's masculinity by precluding him from working, since nonmanual jobs were not considered work.²⁰ This attitude toward nonmanual jobs was particularly significant in relation to the preponderance of Italians in manual rather than white collar jobs in the 1930s.

Whatever the motivation for the Italian response to education, the effects were notable. In the early settlement years, the Italian child was considered a poor student who had difficulty with academic subjects. Truancy among this ethnic group was significant. The problems with schooling continued. A Board of Education study in 1926 noted that only 11.1 percent of Italian-Americans who entered high school graduated.²¹ Efforts to increase the level of education among Italian children met with continued apathy in the Italian community. An Education Committee of the New York State Sons of Italy was set up in the late 1920s, yet no money was forthcoming from the state body. An attempt by the City to change the plans for a school in an Italian community from academic to vocational was met with apathy among the Italians, who did not care whether the school was academic or vocational. Yet there was interest in education by those in the Italian community who were already well-educated, as well as a feeling of inferiority concerning educational achievement. This is best illustrated by an article in the *Casa Italiana Bulletin* (associated with Columbia University), which noted that "students of Italian origin are attending High School in ever increasing numbers. They are learning to hold their own very effectively not only on the athletic field but in scholarship as well." The article went on to declare that two Italian boys graduated from DeWitt Clinton High School with a grade average above 90 percent. "We have evidence," the article noted, "that this is neither an accident nor an isolated fact."²²

The effects of the Italian and Jewish attitudes toward education were illustrated by a Welfare Council of New York study in 1935 based on a sample of the population of the City in the 16- to 24-year-old age group. The report stated that the "youth of Italian parentage deviate considerably from youth of native parentage as regards . . . the extent of school attendance. . . . Both boys and girls of Italian stock have the smallest proportion of any white group attending school." The same report noted that the foreign stock Jews have almost as high a proportion of their youth in schools and colleges as those youth with native parents. A part of this 1935 survey which was published earlier commented that the rate of college graduation was four times greater among Jewish boys than among non-

Jews.²³ The Italian and Jewish attitudes toward education and their involvement with the schools had a direct effect on their occupational positions.

Also important in determining the Italian's place in the occupational hierarchy was the initial desire of many immigrants to return to Italy, thereby preventing them from taking an active interest in improving their lot in America. Italians, unlike the Jews, did not at first join the growing unions which were striving to provide better living conditions, although many did so later on. While self-help mutual benefit societies, organized to aid the immigrants, were found in both Italian and Jewish communities, the Jews, with financial support from earlier German Jewish immigrants, were able to extend more benefits to their population.

THE DEPRESSION YEARS: ITALIANS AND JEWS

The basic weakness in the Italian occupational structure was obvious during the initial immigration period as well as in the 1930s. Tables 5 and 6, which list the occupations of Italian-born fathers of children born in New York in 1916 and 1931, suggests the significant percentage of unskilled laborers dominating the

Table 5. Occupations: Italian-born Fathers of Children Born in New York City in 1916

	Number	Percent
Laborer	15,905	50.4
Tailor	1,697	5.4
Barber	1,667	5.3
Shoemaker	909	2.9
Carpenter	651	2.1
Longshoreman	596	1.9
Driver	546	1.7
Coal man	325	1.0
Businessman	289	.9
Mechanic	278	.9
Other ^a	8,663	27.5
Total	31,556	100.0

SOURCE: John J. D'Alesandre, "Occupational Trends of Italians in New York City," *Italy America Monthly* 2 (1935):15.

^aIncludes a series of twenty-eight occupations such as cook, baker, painter, bricklayer, and printer, none of which amounts to more than 0.8 percent.

Table 6. Occupations: Italian-born Fathers of Children Born in New York City in 1931

	Number	Percent
Laborer	5,321	31.4
Barber	850	5.0
Tailor	713	4.2
Shoemaker	633	3.7
Chauffeur	608	3.6
Carpenter	429	2.5
Ice dealer	392	2.3
Painter	379	2.2
Mechanic	363	2.1
Plasterer	306	1.8
Other ^a	6,951	41.2
Total	16,945	100.0

SOURCE: John J. D'Alesandre, "Occupational Trends of Italians in New York City," *Italy America Monthly* 2 (1935):15.

^aIncludes a series of twenty-nine occupations such as longshoremen, clerk, salesman, baker, and bricklayer, none of which amounts to more than 1.5 percent. Proprietors were only 0.5 percent.

Italian occupational scene in both years.²⁴ In 1916 laborers represented 50.4 percent of the list; by 1931 the largest category was still that of laborer, although it had decreased to 31.4 percent. This decline may have been the result of the Depression, which, by devastating the construction industry, decreased the need for laborers in this field and caused an unwilling exodus into other occupations. It is also notable that more Italian-born fathers were found in skilled occupations by 1931. Plasterers (1.8 percent) and painters (2.2 percent) appear in the top ten occupations by 1931. Mechanics, who in 1916 made up .9 percent of the total, were 2.1 percent in 1931.

By indicating a higher percentage of workers in skilled positions than before, the Italian immigrant occupational structure in 1931 fits the general City and State pattern. However, as compared to the City's other ethnic groups, as will be noted later, the Italian position was still not an economically strong one. Immigrant Italians classified as laborers or as workers in the construction trades numbered 41.6 percent of this list. Nearly half of the Italian-born fathers in 1931 were in occupations which were severely affected by the Depression.

Other studies reveal that during the 1930s the Italians were mainly in skilled, semiskilled, and unskilled manual occupations, while the Jews were

*Jews in better
economic
position than
Italians*

represented not only in skilled and semiskilled work but also in managerial and employer positions.

The Welfare Council of New York, through their 1935 study, was able to determine the usual occupations of the fathers of the youths in the sample. Of those fathers born in Russia (whom the survey identified as Jewish), 3.8 percent were professionals and 31.8 percent of the 1,642 in the sample were proprietors, managers, and officials.²⁵ The clerical division made up 6.8 percent, the skilled 23.1 percent, and the semiskilled 29.8 percent of the Jewish sample. Jews in service occupations numbered 2.1 percent. Only 2.6 percent of the Jewish fathers were listed as unskilled. In the same study, 1.1 percent of a sample of 1,964 Italians were listed as professionals, 17 percent as proprietors, managers, and officials, 2.8 percent in clerical positions, 23.3 percent as skilled, 27.8 percent as semiskilled, and 23.4 percent unskilled. There were also 4.6 percent in the service category. It is evident on the basis of this study that the Jews were strongly represented in managerial and proprietary positions as well as in skilled and semiskilled occupations. The Italians also had concentrated in skilled and semiskilled work but still had many in the unskilled category. The Welfare Council report noted that "almost twice as many of the youth of Italian parentage as of the other foreign stock has fathers whose usual occupation was in unskilled labor."²⁶

Similar conclusions could be reached by considering just the youth. With data based on the 1935 survey, it was noted that "Jews, both male and female, had a greater proportion of employed youth in professional, clerical, and managerial work than did non-Jews." For example, although the Jewish youth comprised 33 percent of those in the 16- to 24-year-old age group who were employed, they represented "56 percent of the youth of this age group employed in proprietary and managerial work, 43 percent of those in clerical and sales positions, [and] 37 percent of youth in the professions." Among the skilled and semiskilled, Jewish youth comprised 24 percent, with 10 percent unskilled and 5 percent in service occupations. The study also noted that the Jewish youth were more likely than the non-Jews to be working at a job "of a higher socio-economic grade than that of the parent."²⁷ All reports on Jewish employment, for youth and others, indicated a predilection for white-collar positions, particularly in proprietary, clerical, sales, and professional occupations.

The effects of these occupational choices can be seen in the unemployment and relief figures. There was less unemployment among Jewish youth than among the non-Jews—a situation attributed to the higher educational position of the Jews. Italians, among all white groups, had the highest proportion of their youth unemployed. Similarly, Jewish youth on relief numbered 12.2 percent of the total Jewish sample, while relief among Italian youth reached 21 percent. Looking at families on relief, we see that 12 percent of the Jewish youth were in such families, compared with 15 percent of the non-Jewish white youth.²⁸

High upward
mobility
for
Jews?

This, of course, does not indicate that Jews as a group were unaffected by the Depression. Since Jews were found in many industries, particularly the apparel trades, which were hard hit by the Depression, they also suffered. In fact, by December 1937, during the recession, Jewish gainful workers, comprising 27.4 percent of all gainful workers in the City, were 33.3 percent of the total gainful workers unemployed.²⁹ However, the advantageous position of the Jewish youth and the fact that many Jews were in the relatively more stable white-collar and proprietary positions and in skilled rather than unskilled work gave the impression to some that the Jews were not affected by the Depression. Also notable in perpetuating this impression was the fact that many Jews were employers, controlling or dominating a number of industries in the City.

The Jewish occupational structure of New York City was studied further in 1937 by the Committee on Economic Adjustment of the American Jewish Committee and the Conference on Jewish Relations, using figures obtained from trade associations and labor unions. The report revealed that 25.4 percent of the 924,258 Jewish gainful workers, both immigrants and native-born, were engaged in manufacturing. The other major categories included 25.7 percent in trade, 10.9 percent in domestic and personal service, 7.4 percent in professional work, 5.2 percent in construction, and 13.5 percent unemployed. Small percentages of Jews were scattered in such categories as finance, transportation, public service, amusement, and public utilities.³⁰

These figures become more meaningful when it is noted that Jews predominated as employers rather than as employees. While the Jews owned almost two-thirds of the 34,000 factories in New York City, they composed only one-third of the workers. In trade, the Jews were the proprietors of two-thirds of the 103,854 wholesale and retail establishments, but only 37.8 percent of the workers were Jewish. The Jews also constituted two-thirds of the owners of the 11,000 restaurants and lunchrooms (classified under domestic and personal service) but only 15 percent of the workers were of this group. Even in construction, 4,000 of the 10,000 builders were Jewish, although this group made up only 14.4 percent of the gainful workers in this field. The study concluded that there was a concentration of Jews in employer and semi-employer categories "where they have at least a measure of independence."³¹ A number of these businesses were small enterprises.

In a number of situations, Jewish employers dominated industries which employed an increasing number of Italian workers. For example, in the men's clothing industry by 1938 the Italians represented the largest single group of workers, while the executives and foremen in the factories were predominantly Jewish. This situation was also true in other areas of the clothing industry. Many unions which had large numbers of Italian members found their work to be dependent on Jewish contractors and manufacturers. This was true in such unions as the Painters Brotherhood local 874, the International Ladies Garment Workers Union local 89, and the Bedding local 140 of the United Furniture Workers of

So Italians during the Depression might think they were being subsidized

America. Of course there were also a number of unions and industries dominated by Italians with little dependence on Jews. These would include the Transportation and Communications workers (particularly longshoremen) and the barbers union. However, the occupational areas in which Italians were dependent on Jews and saw themselves in lower status positions was plentiful enough to have caused an undercurrent of Italian resentment based on envy of Jewish success. Resentment related to general Depression frustrations may also have existed as a product of the widespread unemployment among Italian youth during the economic collapse. Some Jewish resentment against Italians was evident too because of the competition between the two groups for jobs in such areas as the ladies garment industry. As the number of Italians in the union and industry grew and the number of Jews decreased, the resentment increased.³²

While Jews predominated as employers, they also dominated certain areas within specific occupational categories such as professional work. Jews in professional service, according to the 1937 study, made up 7.4 percent of the total Jewish gainful workers, while only 6.6 percent of all gainful workers were in professional service in New York. Jews especially were concentrated in medicine, law, and dentistry. A study of Jewish lawyers in New York notes that in the period 1930–34 there was an increase in the number of Jewish lawyers admitted to the bar, with the most being admitted in 1931; these people had begun their law studies before the Depression. Specifically, while 27.9 percent of all lawyers admitted to the bar prior to 1935 were admitted in the 1930–34 period, 41.5 percent of the Jewish lawyers were admitted during this period. An upsurge of Jews entering the law profession occurred at the same time the Depression was forcing some lawyers into unemployment.³³ However, these Jewish lawyers were able to enter readily the expanding civil service, which, because of admission changes brought about by Mayor Fiorello La Guardia, was increasingly open to people with an education.

Although Jewish occupational success caused some difficulties in inter-group relations with their co-arrivals, it posed a more serious problem to relations with the already established and older ethnic groups who were watching their hard-won gains being destroyed by the Depression.

GERMANS AND IRISH: A COMPARISON

The Depression had seriously affected all the ethnics, but the older groups, because they had worked for so long to attain their position in society, felt the shock of the economic collapse more severely. One of the great misfortunes of this period was that the Jews, and to a lesser extent the Italians, emerged once again as strong competitors at about the same time that the country was hurled into the Depression.³⁴ *Viewed as threats due to competition for scarce resources*

In the early years of Jewish and Italian immigration, and continuing into the

Stronger economic position →
less friction in the face of
competition + economic problems

twentieth century, both the Irish and Germans had faced job competition from the newer groups. In the construction trades, as unskilled laborers and as longshoremen, the Irish and Italians were rivals for positions. Italians had also competed with the Irish for unskilled city jobs. In the apparel trades German and Irish workers became less important in an industry increasingly dominated by Jews and Italians. However, because the Germans as a group were in a stronger occupational and economic position than the Irish, less friction with the newcomers was generated by the economic issue, even with increasing job competition.³⁵

Even during the period of first settlement in the mid-nineteenth century, the Germans exhibited a superior occupational level.³⁶ A report of the Immigration Commission substantiates this point for a later period by noting that of the Germans entering in the 1899–1910 period and reporting an occupation, 30 percent of the 458,293 immigrants were skilled, as compared to only 12.6 percent of the 376,268 Irish arriving and reporting an occupation. There were other indications of German and Irish occupational positions as well. An analysis of the 1890 census, which indicated the occupations of the foreign-born workers, revealed that the Germans (males) were particularly concentrated in the manufacturing category as brewers, food industry workers (for example, bakers and butchers), clothing workers (tailors, seamstresses), and skilled craftsmen such as basket- and cabinetmakers, gunsmiths and locksmiths, trunk makers, and piano makers and tuners. There was also a significant German concentration in the occupation of saloon keeper.³⁷

The foreign-born Irish (males) in 1890 were mainly concentrated “in domestic and personal service, as watchmen [and policemen], nurses, soldiers, janitors, laborers, sextons, [and] servants.” Other occupations with a significant Irish concentration were porters, foremen, hostlers, saloon keepers, and gas works and street railway employees. The Irish in general were under-represented in the skilled occupations, although they did have some concentrations in such skilled positions as stone masons and plasterers. Compared to the total white population and to the other immigrant groups, the Irish also had a higher proportion of their workers in government work; they were well represented in factory labor, too.³⁸

Analysis of the Immigration Commission’s data from the United States census of 1900 provides similar information. The German male immigrant was mainly employed in manufacturing; the Irish male immigrant’s main employment was in domestic and personal service. In terms of specific occupations (listed in order of concentration), the German immigrants were found in the category of tailors, saloon keepers and bartenders, tobacco and cigar factory operatives, and boot- and shoemakers and repairers. The Irish immigrants (again in order of concentration) were found in the categories of servants and waiters, masons (brick and stone), saloon keepers and bartenders and laborers. This employment pattern for the Germans reveals a stronger occupational structure which was better geared to the coming trend toward more highly skilled occupa-

tions. Second-generation Germans in 1900 show a continued concentration in skilled and semi-skilled labor, and second-generation Irish indicate a movement into the skilled and semi-skilled fields. The Germans (in order of concentration) were found in the categories of tobacco and cigar factory operatives, saloon keepers and bartenders, printers, lithographers and pressmen, and salesmen. They had also shown increases as bookkeepers and accountants, clerks, and in the building trades. The Irish noted great diversification in occupations by the second generation and were found in a number of skilled occupations. In order of concentration, they were primarily in the categories of building trades, both skilled and unskilled, saloon keepers and bartenders, textile mill operatives (except cotton), and teamsters. There were notable increases in such occupations as bookkeepers and accountants, clerks, and salesmen. However, the Irish also continued to show a generally weaker occupational structure than the Germans. For example, although Irish concentration in the unskilled laboring class had decreased, laborers were still slightly more common among the second-generation Irish than among the total second-generation population. Among Germans, the figure indicated an under-representation in this occupational division. The same pattern was true for both groups in the category of servants and waiters.³⁹ Both ethnic communities were to find many of their workers in upper-level and skilled occupations by the Depression era, although the Germans, as a group, still seemed to be in a stronger position by the 1930s. The Irish, however, had entrenched themselves in such sought-after areas as civil service.

upward mobility to some degree

productivity to more or less fraction in fact or economic crisis

The Welfare Council study on the youth of New York offers some proof of this assertion by providing data on foreign-born fathers in 1935. Of 272 German-born fathers in the sample, 4 percent were professionals, 26.5 percent were proprietors, managers, and officials, 9.5 percent were clerical, 11.8 percent were service, 28.3 percent skilled, 16.9 percent semi-skilled, and 2.6 percent unskilled. Among the 388 Irish in the sample, only 1.3 percent were professionals, 9.8 percent proprietors, managers, and officials, 6.2 percent clerical, 6.2 percent service, 36.8 percent skilled, 27.6 percent semi-skilled, and 12.1 percent unskilled.⁴⁰ If these figures can be taken as an indication of the general German and Irish occupational structure, then a larger percentage of Germans were in the more stable occupational categories during the Depression era, especially as professionals and proprietors, managers and officials; and a smaller percentage were in the devastated unskilled area. Although census data on what specific industries or occupations the manual workers of each group were concentrated in is not available, other evidence notes a strong Irish presence in the hard-hit construction industry and in longshoremen and teamster positions.⁴¹ On the basis of the 1935 data, the Germans compared well with the Jews, and both showed a stronger occupational structure than either the Irish or Italians. The only difference was the presence of the Irish in such relatively stable fields as teaching and civil service.

so less likely to be confident there

This general picture, however, does not fully explain the ethnic tensions associated with the economic factor. One cannot assume that all Germans were in

a better economic position than all Irish simply because the overall occupational level of the Germans was superior. Many Germans were in job categories severely affected by the Depression. Moreover, some German-American neighborhoods in the City, such as Ridgewood, Queens, were poorer (classified as lower-middle- and lower-class) in 1940 than areas such as Fordham in the Bronx, where many Irish lived (classified as middle- and lower-middle-class).⁴² Both areas had been downwardly mobile during the 1930s.

Interestingly, in even the poorer German communities little evidence of an economic factor in the conflict with the Jews could be found, while it was noticeable in all Irish neighborhoods. Although surely some German economic resentments existed, for various reasons it did not find expression on a group level or in the press. The Nazi German-American Bund tried to make an issue of Jewish occupational gains, but it seemed to arouse no interest in the German community. Jews were criticized a number of times in the German-American press, but no mention was made of Jewish occupational competition or success. Although there was evidence of conflict with the Jews in German neighborhoods, there is no basis for stating that these actions were directed against the Jews because of economic resentments. Other issues, such as the anti-Nazi boycott discussed in chapter 4, form the basis of German-Jewish conflict. To understand why even the poorer Germans did not react to this issue, one must note that there was little direct economic competition between these groups and therefore little identification of the Jews as realistically threatening the German economic position. However, even general Depression resentments were not aimed at the Jews. After the "Roosevelt Recession," when bitterness over the new economic collapse brought to the surface the realistic and unrealistic components of the economic factor in the conflict between the Irish and Jews, the Germans as a group did not express these feelings.⁴³ Perhaps by 1938 sensitivity to the Nazi issue and to expressing overt anti-Semitic statements muted these attitudes. Fearful of being labeled Nazis at a time when American public opinion was reacting against Germany and its policies, and having within their City both a vocal and embarrassing Bund chapter and a large and powerful Jewish community ready to retaliate against those thought to be Nazis, most German-Americans, while perhaps sharing with the Irish these resentments, did not express them or otherwise act them out. There was also, in contrast to the Irish community, no respectable leader of the Germans who voiced the economic grievances. Of course, some German-Americans expressed these attitudes by joining anti-Semitic organizations, but few were involved.

DISPLACEMENT OF THE IRISH AND OTHER ETHNIC PROBLEMS

The Irish on the whole not only were harder hit by the Depression than the Germans but also were more concentrated in jobs which were particularly sought

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after by the newer ethnics. The Irish had a definite penchant for civil service jobs, politics, law, and the church. Caroline Ware, in her study of Greenwich Village, notes that the Irish who lived there had a definite rating scale of occupations. Janitors, watchmen, and scrubwomen were at the nadir of the economic and social ladder. At the next level were longshoremen, auto mechanics, truckdrivers, and some occupations within the building trades. Policemen, firemen, office workers, and other civil service posts were considered superior to positions at the longshoremen and artisan level. White-collar and city jobs were regarded as better than blue-collar positions. The occupations of politician, lawyer, real estate man, doctor, and clergyman were regarded as the pinnacle of the social ladder. For women, the most prestigious occupation was the teaching profession. According to Ware, "economic and occupational position gave a recognized status within the Irish community," and "all were constantly seeking to climb, or at least to maintain the position on the ladder which they had." Civil service jobs were recognized as a particularly important step upward and something to be desired for their children.⁴⁴ The close ties between the Irish and politics provided a steady flow of civil service jobs into the Irish community. However, the Irish were soon to lose their hold on these valued and relatively stable positions.

The election of Fiorello La Guardia as Mayor in 1933 provided a change in civil service appointments. Before the advent of La Guardia, Jews, Italians, and blacks had been discriminated against when applying for civil service jobs; most of the positions had gone to the Irish. Mayor La Guardia, however, increased the number of civil service jobs in the competitive category. In 1933, 54.5 percent of the city workers were in the competitive class; by 1939, 74.3 percent were within this group. The number of exempt (appointive) and noncompetitive jobs (requiring only a qualifying exam) were reduced. Furthermore, to take a minimum entrance exam for certain positions, a high school diploma was needed. According to one individual who was prominent in the Irish community during the 1930s, the educational requirement had the effect of eliminating many Irish, particularly of the first and second generations, who did not have the necessary schooling but nonetheless desired civil service jobs. Thus La Guardia managed to increase the number of non-Irish, notably the better-educated Jews, in the City's civil service. The working class Irish bore the brunt of this job loss, which came at a time when employment was hard to find. It was natural for them to feel resentment toward the Jews, who were the major competitors for these positions.⁴⁵ The La Guardia administration also made an effort to eliminate political influence and ethnic discrimination for those already in the civil service. Through job ratings and exams, employees were given the opportunity to rise in the civil service more on the basis of their abilities than political connections.

Within the teaching profession, so highly regarded by Irish women, there is also evidence to suggest that the Jews were displacing the other groups. One study based on a random sampling of teacher's names in the New York City school system noted that "the majority of teachers entering the system in the

This could become a problem if opportunities become scarcer

early years of the century were of Christian backgrounds and the majority of teachers entering the system since the late thirties have been of Jewish background." The study concluded that in 1914 only 22 percent of the teachers entering the school system were Jewish. The Jewish percentage had increased to 26 percent by 1920, 44 percent by 1930, and 56 percent by 1940.⁴⁶ It is clear, if this study's findings can be accepted, that teaching was one profession which the Jews were entering in significant numbers.

Who were the Christian teachers in the early years of the century? An Immigration Commission study in 1908–09, through the use of questionnaires, classified elementary school teachers in the City by nationality background. The report concluded that the first- and second-generation Irish made up 20.7 percent of the 14,900 teachers. The German foreign stock was 8.7 percent; the southern Italians were .12 percent; and the Jews made up 11.3 percent of this occupational group. The Jews and Irish were therefore the two main ethnic groups (excluding third-generation native-born of undetermined ethnic background) involved in the teaching profession in 1908–09.⁴⁷ Certainly the influx of Jews into this occupation served as competition for the Irish and others who wanted such jobs. Table 7 corroborates the other studies by noting when teachers who were serving in the Manhattan School system in 1937 first entered that system. While the majority of Jewish teachers received their jobs after 1920 (70.8 percent), the majority of Irish and German teachers entered the system before 1920 (57.5 percent and 60.7 percent respectively). By the 1920s and 1930s, not only were Jews entering the teaching profession as never before but (because of a declining birth rate, a population shift to the suburbs, decreased immigration, and the Depression) there were fewer teaching jobs available. The majority of jobs, however, as noted in the Cole study, were going to the Jews. What this meant, in terms of schools, can be illustrated by an example drawn from the South Bronx, an area which exploded in anti-Semitic hostilities in the late 1930s. At Public School 9 (138th and 139th streets, west of Brook Avenue), while only 7 percent of the student body was Jewish, 75 percent of the teachers were of this ethnic group. The area surrounding the school was mixed but predominantly Irish.⁴⁸

Since the Irish were concerned about occupational status, the increased competition from the Jews in such areas as teaching, civil service, and law contributed to their resentments. Cultural differences also played a role in increasing tensions. There were also no mitigating factors, as with the Germans, which would have muted the expression of hostility on this point. The Irish were the main older group both to lose economic status because of the Depression and to face severe competition from the newer ethnics. According to various studies, the process of downward occupational mobility, by those who are concerned about status, results in "hostility feelings toward minority groups, who are engaged in bettering a lower social position or maintaining a newly-won higher status." These status-oriented, downwardly mobile individuals tend to be the most prejudiced. There is also a high degree of prejudice among those who are

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status- or mobility-oriented but who have failed to advance.⁴⁹ The increasing economic frustrations of the Irish and their attitudes towards the Jews were well reflected in their press and indicated an awareness of the struggle.

The *Brooklyn Tablet*, official diocese paper of Brooklyn, complained repeatedly during the 1930s that Catholics were being discriminated against and that anti-Christianity, not anti-Semitism, was the real problem in New York.⁵⁰ One editorial in the *Tablet* noted that Catholics in Brooklyn were under-represented in the Emergency Relief Bureau and in many situations had been replaced or not hired.⁵¹ Patrick Scanlan, managing editor of the *Tablet*, also urged Catholics to apply for civil service jobs in greater numbers in order to drive out the leftists. In the Irish press Leftists, Communists or Reds frequently meant Jewish liberals. Scanlan also stated that local people "without diplomas or fancy salaries" should administer relief.⁵²

The fact that some jobs were going to the better-educated Jews irked the Irish, who found themselves at an occupational disadvantage just when jobs were scarce. In 1934 the *Gaelic American* appealed to Irish-American parents to let their children stay in school. The editorial stated that it was a mistake to consider a person educated when he finished elementary or high school. "To the credit of our Jewish fellow citizens," the paper continued, "it must be said that they take full advantage of these free educational facilities [city colleges]." In another instance of resentment and awareness of Jewish education, *Social Justice*, a paper read by many Irish, complained that the New York police, largely Irish, would soon have "Reds" placed over them by the Civil Service Commission. These "Reds," according to the paper, were college graduates who would now be given preference for promotion within the force. *Social Justice* continued by wondering whether now "a man must be up on his Greek, mathematics, zoology, astronomy and Hebrew before he can be a good cop." One interesting letter to the editor of the *Tablet* noted that of 2,734 names on a civil service eligibility list for the position of Social Investigator, "over 1,700 or 62 percent of these names are obviously Jewish. Less than 100 names are Irish. Such a result should give Catholic leaders pause for thought." The writer continued by asking whether anything could be done "or are Catholics doomed to exclusion from the field of Public Welfare as they have gradually been excluded from the field of Public Education?"⁵³

The *Tablet* also complained about the lack of Catholics in the professions. Essentially, the Irish were upset that they had been in the City longer yet the Jews were surging ahead in the higher and more stable occupations. "Just look at the doctors' shingles in any neighborhood and behold how few Catholics are indicated," commented the *Tablet*. Scanlan asked, on one occasion, what the Jews had to complain about when "in the professions, civil service, schools and public life they are represented out of all proportion to their numbers." One Irish writer to the *Tablet*, noting that the Jews seem to control 75 percent of the professions, asked what Catholics can do to improve their lot.⁵⁴

In the late 1930s one of the frequent complaints of the mainly Irish and violently anti-Semitic Christian Front, when they held their street-corner rallies, was that the Jews controlled all the good jobs and businesses. This thought was echoed by many of the anti-Jewish vandals, most of whom were Irish, who were arrested in the early 1940s.⁵⁵ It is clear that there was a feeling of displacement among the Irish, coupled with a growing resentment of Jewish success. The Depression, making certain occupations such as civil service more valuable, made the Irish all the more aware of Jewish competition and their own failings.

The Jews also had occupational problems at this time, but theirs were related primarily to discrimination. They had experienced discrimination many times before, but the 1930s was a unique era. A study conducted by the American Jewish Congress in 1938 noted that the frequency of anti-Jewish specifications in help-wanted ads was at an all-time high.⁵⁶ Attempts to limit the number of Jews in medical and other professional schools also increased during the 1930s.⁵⁷

The discrimination of this period put the Jews into an extremely defensive and worried position. One Jewish periodical, noting that Jews were crowding into law and medical school, suggested that Jewish youth look to other professions.⁵⁸ It was thought that a dispersion of Jews into different fields would result in a decrease in occupational discrimination.

Because of these factors, as well as others, the Jews began to feel increasingly insecure and eventually reacted accordingly. The same feeling was evident among the Irish, who were also on the defensive. For the Germans, who were challenged less by the newer groups and seemingly hurt less by the Depression, economic resentment, for these and other reasons, remained muted (though probably present to some degree) and therefore less of a source of intergroup tension. The Italians, although still offering an economic challenge to the Irish in certain areas, posed a lesser threat than the Jews. Also the fact that this group had been seriously hurt by the Depression did not seem to evoke significant feelings of frustration and anger toward others, since, even with the economic collapse, they were showing signs of economic advancement.⁵⁹ The two main antagonists in relation to the tensions associated with ethnic succession, based on the economic factor, were the Irish and Jews. The economic situation was to be just one of the many points of friction which contributed to the intense conflict which emerged between these groups during the decade of the Depression.

Increasing
tensions
leading
to
conflict

Table 7. Sample of Teachers in Manhattan Public Schools in 1936–1937, by Ethnicity and the Years Entered into Teaching

Years of Entry into Teaching	% and number of Jews entering teaching before 1937	% and number of Irish entering teaching before 1937	% and number of Germans entering teaching before 1937	% and number of Italians entering teaching before 1937
1890–1899	5.2	(8)	8.1	(5)
1900–1909	10	(15)	31.1	(19)
1910–1919	14.3	(22)	21.3	(13)
1920–1929	39.6	(61)	31.1	(19)
1930–1937	31.2	(48)	8.2	(5)
Total number in sample		154	160	61
				24

SOURCE: New York City, Department of Education, *List of Members of Board of Education, Local School Boards, Officials, Employees and Supervising and Teaching Staff*, May 1936–March 1937 (New York: 1938) pp. 41–69.

NOTE: In this sample, ethnic identification of the teachers was based on their names. Any ethnically doubtful names were not counted. As an aid to ethnic name identification, the following were used. American Council of Learned Societies, *Report of the Committee on Linguistics and National Stocks in the Population of the United States*, in American Historical Association, *Annual Report*, 1931 4 (1931): 232–48, 271–305; Edward MacLysaght, *A Guide to Irish Surnames* (Baltimore: Geneological Book Company, 1964), and a list of 106 distinctive Jewish names kindly furnished by Dr. Fred Massarik, scientific director of the U.S. National Jewish Population Study. In this computation approximately every fifth Manhattan Public School was counted and included: P.S. 1, 5, 12, 31, 39, 50, 58, 72, 78, 84, 89, 94, 102, 121, 151, 160, 169, 188, 193, and J.H.S. 20, 65, 115, 136.